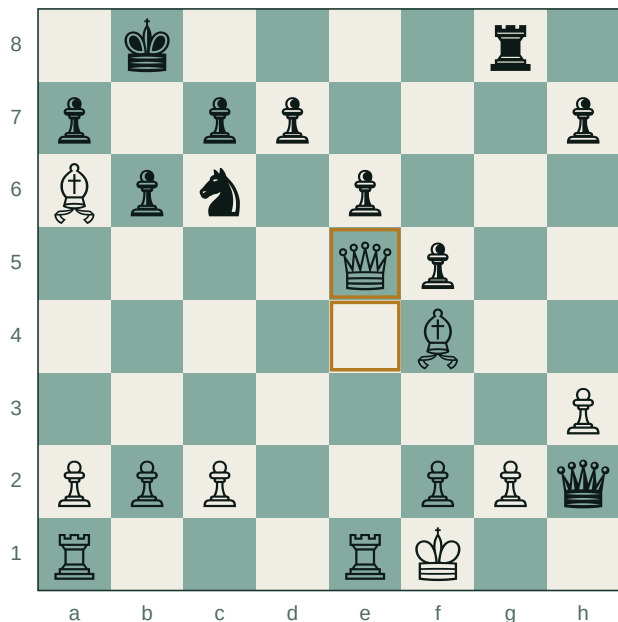


Intermediate moves: Black, move 21

Intermediate moves

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Qxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Qxg2+ 22. Ke2 Nxe5

21...Qxg2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on g2. Recorded reply: **22.Ke2**.

22...Nxe5 The knight captures the queen on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 24 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +10. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +10:** the balance goes from -7 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on f1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on a6. Check for tactical protection.